Ford Motor Company

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INFORMATIONAL SAFETY RECALL COMMUNICATION

TO: All Ford Dealers

REFERENCE: Press Release on Upcoming Safety Recall 02S38: Certain 2002 Model Year Thunderbird - Seat Belt

AFFECTED VEHICLES

Certain 2002 Model Year Thunderbird vehicles built at the Wixom Assembly Plant from the beginning of production through April 24, 2002.

SAFETY CONCERN

During a New Car Assessment Program 35 mph frontal barrier impact test of a 2002 Thunderbird conducted by the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration (NHTSA), the driver side seat belt was partially cut by the seat mechanism. The test dummy was restrained by the seat belt throughout the test.

SERVICE ACTION

Ford wants to add an insert to the driver seat lower trim panel (hidden behind the seat trim) to eliminate the potential for the seat belt to contact the seat mechanism in a severe collision.

PLEASE NOTE: PARTS AND TECHNICAL INSTRUCTIONS ARE NOT AVAILABLE AT THIS TIME TO REPAIR THE CONDITION STATED ABOVE.

You will be notified in a follow-up standard communication (tentatively the week of July 15, 2002).

CUSTOMER NOTIFICATION

Owners of record will be notified approximately June 21, 2002 of this action and advised to contact their dealer after July 22, 2002 when parts are expected to be available at dealerships.

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OASIS / CUSTOMER CONTACT

OASIS will not be activated until parts are available. Dealer involved unit listings will be provided when the final bulletin is issued.

Also, in an attempt to minimize the number of questions that dealers will receive from customers, we have made involved unit data available to both OwnerConnection and CARFAX. This will allow customers who hear of this issue via the media before receiving the Owner Letter to determine their possible involvement via the Internet.

(DEALER ONLY) RECALL QUESTIONS:

Call 1-800-325-5621

ATTACHMENT:

Questions and Answers (Two Pages)

Sincerely,

Frank M. Ligon

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QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q1. What is the issue?

A. The driver seat belt was partially cut during a 35 mile per hour New Car Assessment Program frontal barrier impact test conducted by the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration. The partial cut occurred when the plastic lower outboard seat trim panel cracked and allowed the belt to contact the seat recliner mechanism. The belt remained intact and restrained the test dummy throughout the crash. The partial cut occurred near the end of the event while the belt was relaxing.

Q2. Did the cut seat belt result affect the results of the test?

A. No. In fact, preliminary information is that the car passed the test with high scores.

Q3. What safety test was this, and how did the Thunderbird score?

A. The test was part of the NHTSA's ongoing assessment of new car performance done on all manufacturers' vehicles. Preliminary indications are that the Thunderbird scored a four-star rating on the driver side, and a five-star score on the passenger side.

Q4. Have there been any reports from customers of this happening?

A. No.

Q5. Does Ford believe there is a safety defect with the seat or seat belt?

A. Ford does not believe the partial cut of the seat belt in this test is an indication of a real-world risk to customers. The preliminary NHTSA NCAP test score (four-star/five-star) demonstrates that the belt cut did not affect the safe performance of the Thunderbird in the test.

Q6. Why not?

A. First, the seat belt remained intact and fully restrained the test dummy throughout the test. Second, our subsequent testing shows the partial seat belt cut occurred late in the test. Finally, the conditions simulated in the test are extremely severe.

Q7. Then why is Ford conducting a voluntary safety recall of the car if it does not believe the car is defective?

A. We are taking this action as part of our continuous improvement efforts.

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Q8. Was Ford forced into this action by NHTSA?

A. Ford discussed the test results and our planned action with the agency.

Q9. What is the fix?

A. Dealers will install an insert behind the driver seat lower trim panel to eliminate the possibility of belt contact with the seat mechanism. The insert will not be visible.

Q10. Why aren't you also reinforcing the passenger side?

A. The passenger side seat belt was not damaged during the test. The passenger seat and related geometry are different than the driver seat.

Q11. Are parts available now?

A. No. We expect parts to be available no later than July 22.

Q12. What about consumers who do not feel safe with the current seat system and who want an immediate remedy?

A. Ford does not believe the current seat and seat belt system pose a risk to occupant safety.

Q13. Why are vehicles produced before and after the dates covered by this recall not included in it?

A. The March 14, 2001 date marks the start of pre-production units for the Thunderbird, which is in its first model year. Cars built after April 24, 2002, have revised parts installed at the plant.

Q14. Any accidents or injuries caused by this condition?

A. None.

Q15. When will you alert owners?

A. Beginning June 21.

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